

Universal emotions and the limits of linguistic evidence

Juan R. Loaiza
Departamento de Filosofía
Universidad Alberto Hurtado

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Language and Basic Emotions

Is linguistic evidence against the Theory of Basic Emotions (BET) relevant?

Wiltschko (2024) believes there are three linguistic arguments against BET.

- Argument from lexical differences
- Argument from phenomenology
- Argument from grammar

Claim

Negative Claim: Linguistic arguments are not relevant to the [ontology](#) of BET.

- BET can accommodate linguistic evidence without violating its core commitments.
- The discussion around language and BET is misfocused.

Positive Claim: Linguistic arguments are relevant to the [epistemology](#) of BET.

- They hold that the evidence in favor of BET is inadequate.
- They establish possible linguistic biases that artificially favor BET.

Core Commitments

- (1) Every emotion depends on a subset of *basic emotions*.
- (2) An emotion is basic if:
 - Evolutionarily ancient
 - Neurophysiologically specific
 - Universal

Background: Darwin (2009)

Classic versions:

- Ekman's Neurocultural Theory²
- Izard's *Differential Emotions Theory*³
- Panksepp's *Affective Neuroscience*⁴

Contemporary versions:

- Cowen and Keltner's *Semantic Space Theory*

Darwin, C. (2009). *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals* (P. Ekman, ed.; 4th ed., 200th anniversary ed). Oxford University Press.

²Ekman, P. (1992). An Argument for Basic Emotions. *Cognition & Emotion*, 6(3), 169-200. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02699939208411068>

³Izard, C. E. (2007). Basic Emotions, Natural Kinds, Emotion Schemas, and a New Paradigm. *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, 2(3), 260-280. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1745-6916.2007.00044.x>

⁴Panksepp, J. (1998). *Affective Neuroscience: The Foundations of Human and Animal Emotions*. Oxford University Press.

Argument from Lexical Differences

[...] languages differ significantly in the set of words denoting emotion concepts [...]. Not all languages have words for the basic emotions postulated and existing words for emotion concepts typically do not refer to the same state across different languages. This leads [...] to the view that emotion concepts are constructed, thus providing an argument against the theory of basic emotions. (Wiltschko, 2024, p. 7)

Argument from Lexical Differences

- (P1) Not all languages have words or concepts that refer to «basic emotions.»
- (P2) If there are basic emotions, they must entail words or concepts to refer to them.
- (C) There are no basic emotions.

Argument from Lexical Differences

«(P2) If there are basic emotions, they must entail words or concepts to refer to them.»

This premise is clearly false.

- BET does not commit to the association between basic emotions and words/concepts.
- It is possible for basic emotions to exist without any language referring to them (e.g., non-human animals, prelinguistic infants)

Argument from Phenomenology

The second language-based argument against a theory of basic emotions has to do with the finding that language influences the quality (if not perception) of emotions [...]. Thus, language (mostly in the form of words for emotion concepts) must be one of the components that contribute to the construction of emotions [...]. (Wiltschko, 2024, p. 7)

Argument from Phenomenology

(P1) Differences in the language of emotions (words, expressions, etc.) lead to phenomenological differences about emotions.

(P1.1) Language has influence over the phenomenology of emotions.

(P2) If there are basic emotions, language has no influence over their phenomenology.

(C) There are no basic emotions.

Argument from Phenomenology

«(P2) If there are basic emotions, language has no influence over their phenomenology.»

Hypothesis: Basic emotions are informationally encapsulated.

- Encapsulation derives from the evolutionary antiquity of emotions.¹
- It guarantees informational separation between language and emotion.

¹Majeed, R. (2023). Does the Problem of Variability Justify Barrett's Emotion Revolution?. *Review of Philosophy and Psychology*, 14(4), 1421-1441. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s13164-022-00650-0>

Argument from Phenomenology

BET does not commit to modularity or encapsulation of basic emotions.

Even accepting encapsulation, we can distinguish modular activity from conscious activity.

- Phenomenology occurs at a higher computational level than modular activity.
- Language affects conscious experience, not low-level activity.

Argument from Grammar

According to the theory of basic emotions, there is a small set of primitive emotions. If this were the case, there would be no obvious reason why grammatical categories dedicated to the expression of emotions are not attested.[...] Why is it that we frequently find tense, person, and number categories, but not anger, fear, or happiness? [...] (Wiltschko, 2024, pp. 30-31)

Examples:

- [I live in Bogotá]-Happy
- [I live in Bogotá]-Sad

Argument from Grammar

(P1) There are no grammatical categories for emotional expressions.

(P2) If there are basic emotions, there must be grammatical categories for emotional expressions.

(C) There are no basic emotions.

Argument from Grammar

«(P2) If there are basic emotions, there must be grammatical categories for emotional expressions.»

Functional-typological theories

Grammatical categories develop through use and reflect human interests.

Cognitive theories

Grammatical categories reflect common knowledge.

Generative theories

Grammatical categories reflect innate universals from our evolutionary history.

Argument from Grammar

BET can explain the absence of grammatical markers.

- Grammatical categories are contingent, not necessary.
- There are other communicative markers for emotions (vocalization, facial and bodily expression, etc.).
- There are no grammatical categories for many universal phenomena (e.g., diseases).

The absence of emotional grammar does not imply that there are no basic emotions.

Summary

BET holds that there are biologically individuated, universal, and socially context-independent emotions.

Wiltschko (2024) holds that there are three linguistic arguments against BET.

- Argument from lexical differences
- Argument from phenomenology
- Argument from grammar

None of the arguments works against the ontology of BET.

Implicit Biases in Emotion Science

It is as though theorists have implicitly assumed that (at least) English lexicalizes all of the basic emotions, and their favorite candidates are the referents of high-frequency English emotion words such as «anger,» «fear,» «enjoyment» (i.e., «happiness»), «sadness,» «disgust,» and «surprise.» How fortunate that the search for basic emotions was not undertaken by Tahitian or Sarawak psychologists. (Ortony, 2022)

Implicit Biases in Emotion Science

Linguistic arguments do not undermine the ontology of BET, but rather **cast doubt** on its evidence.

- How have linguistic biases been controlled in the collection of evidence?
- In their experimental designs?
- In their scientific communities?

It is not causality, but an **artifact**, that the basic categories are those of English.

The Bias Argument

- (P1) Evidence in favor of BET must be obtained in a linguistically controlled manner in order to be adequate.
- (P2) Evidence in favor of BET has not been obtained in a linguistically controlled manner.
- (C) The evidence in favor of BET is inadequate.

The Neutrality or Control Requirement

«Evidence in favor of BET must be obtained in a linguistically controlled manner in order to be valid.»

Without control of linguistic biases, there are two rival hypotheses underdetermined by the evidence:

- (1) English categories **correspond** to natural categories.
- (2) English categories **appear to correspond** to natural categories due to familiarity or linguistic preference.

The preference for (1) suggests anglocentric values in theoretical choice.¹

¹Wierzbicka, A. (2009). Overcoming Anglocentrism in Emotion Research. *Emotion Review*, 1(1), 21-23. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1754073908097179>

Bias Controls

«Evidence in favor of BET has not been obtained in a linguistically controlled manner.»

The three previous arguments provide support for this premise:

- (1) Lexical and grammatical differences indicate relevant differences that have not been taken into account.
- (2) The influence on phenomenology suggests psychological biases for the interpretation of results.

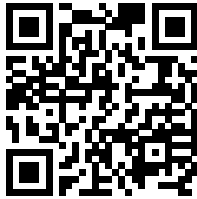
Consequences

If linguistic arguments are not ontological but epistemological, the discussion must take place at the epistemological level.

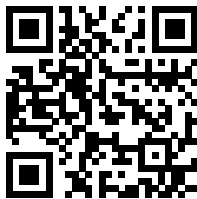
- Have linguistic bias controls been implemented in research?
- What policies would control these linguistic biases?

It is necessary to make transparent the value decisions involved in interpreting the evidence in favor of BET.

¡Gracias!



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